

How to: Peer Review for CHI (and Beyond) 2025

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Abstract

A key challenge for people that are new to reviewing is pitching the review at the right level, and getting the tone and structure of a review right. This course aims to help participants understand a) the different expectations of different venues and submission types, b) the processes they use to make decisions, and c) good techniques for producing a review for these different circumstances. Combined with pre-workshop training videos provided via SIGCHI's Youtube Channel, the practical work of this course will involve: 1) critiquing anonymised but real reviews (as a senior reviewer), and 2) constructing prototype reviews based on advice (as a reviewer).

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Human computer interaction (HCI)**.

Keywords

Peer Review, Reviewing, Reviewer

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1 Introduction

A key challenge for new reviewers is comprehending the expectations that different venues (journals versus conferences versus workshops) may have, for different types of submissions (full papers versus demos versus late breaking work), and the subsequent decisions processes for each. Consequently, it is not uncommon for new reviewers to be unnecessarily harsh or overly lenient on issues for a particular venue and type, and to put too much or too little time into reviews. This problem is exacerbated in highly interdisciplinary research fields like HCI, where even established reviewers need to be aware of expectations for different types of work [8].

At the same time, we are becoming increasingly dependent on expanding the reviewer pool, making tweaks annually to CHI's reviewing process to reduce demand in the face of annual growth in submission numbers [3] (reaching more than 5,000 submissions

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Table 1: Two-session Schedule

Pre-workshop		Type
-	Venues and Submission Types	Online Video
-	Roles, Processes, & Decisions	Online Video
-	Producing Useful Reviews	Online Video
Unit	CHI2025 Workshop	
1	Critiquing Examples of Reviews	Practical Work
2	Practising Producing Reviews	Practical Work

for CHI2025). Meanwhile, people in our field raise concerns in community forums¹ about the experience levels of reviewers looking at many CHI papers, whilst others recommend more stringent forms of review to increase rigour in our field [6]. This growth and its demand on increasingly novice reviewers is a concern that many fields experience and try to confront [1, 10].

Encouraging people to review is also a challenge, as we feel busy with many demands, where this feeling was only exacerbated by the COVID-19 pandemic in a way that many researchers still feel as a knock on effect. With many experts being needed further up the reviewer framework (as e.g. senior reviews (ACs) or subcommittee chairs (SCs), we become dependent on new novice reviewers perhaps reviewing for the first time. Many students learn by being coached by their supervisors, perhaps by the supervisor giving students papers to draft-review before completing the review themselves. Many reviewers, however, do not have this opportunity.

1.1 Learning Outcomes

This course² is designed to help people to:

- (1) Understand the different types of contributions submitted to different venues.
- (2) Understand the different processes used by different venues (for different types of submissions)
- (3) Reflect on what senior reviewers want from a review (and therefore how they might be structured)
- (4) Critique example reviews for different types of submissions for different types of venues
- (5) Construct constructive and informative reviews for authors and senior reviewers

1.2 Audience and Prerequisites

This course is aimed at new PhD students, or other students intending to pursue a research programme, or indeed anyone that feels

¹CHI Meta Discussion

²<http://bit.ly/peer-review-tutorial>

that they are ‘new’ to reviewing and want to broaden their experience. The course may also be useful for people that have begun reviewing, but want to be prepared for reviewing contributions in other types of venues. In general, there are no prerequisites to participating in the course.

2 Course Content

The course, which has been delivered in person at 6 previous occasions, and fully online three times³, is broken up into two main halves: 1) pre-workshop learning material delivered online, and 2) practical work in-person that helping people to apply the lessons learned in practice.

Pre-Workshop Material will focus on the first three learning outcomes. It is intended to help participants reflect on why we submit different types of submissions to different venues, what those venues want, and then how to construct a review to meet those. For example, a workshop typically wants material that invokes discussion and presents exciting early ideas. Whereas full peer-reviewed venues like journals and some high ranking conferences, want important, novel, significant, and rigorous submissions. By doing this, we also discuss the different roles involved in making the decision, and the processes used by people in those roles to make them. We compare, therefore, typical journal processes (including advertised flow diagrams, and the instructors experiences as a Deputy Editor and Associate Editor), extreme examples of conference processes (as used at e.g. CHI), and those used by small groups of workshop organisers.

Workshop Practical Work will focus on two approaches to practically putting the pre-workshop material into practice. First, as a group we will critique a series of anonymised proto-reviews (based on reviews that the instructor has had access to in the past), which comes in two challenges: a) identifying the type of venue the review was produced for, and b) what the recommendation of the author is. This is complemented by activity that examines 5 different anonymised proto-reviews for the same journal article, which vary dramatically in their recommendation and quality. Unit 2 will focus then on an opportunity to construct a review based on what was learned so far. Rather than writing an extensive review in class, attendees will be given the basis of a review to restructure into a constructive, positive, and informative review format.

2.1 Resources

Although certain formal guides exist (e.g. [12]), these vary heavily from discipline to discipline. The pre-workshop online content of the course considers official resources produced by publishers like Springer [11], Elsevier [5], and Nature [13], as well as advice from experts in our own community [2, 4, 7, 9]. A recent community contribution is a detailed working-document guide to reviewing for CHI⁴. This course complements such guides (with often act as a checklist and process overview), with more generalised and reflective insights into reviewing practices.

³The course was due to be delivered at CHI2020, but was ultimately cancelled. In 2022, it was collaboratively delivered with another instructor to reach across timezones. In 2023 it returned to an in-person format.

⁴<https://nehakumar.medium.com/an-unofficial-guide-to-seven-stages-of-reviewing-for-chi-7938880fc895>

The main resource of the workshop, therefore, is a short series of three videos that have been released on the SIGCHI Youtube Channel⁵. These videos are a reusable and asynchronous learning material for supporting peer review long term.

From the in-person workshop itself, participants are able to keep the hard copies of the example reviews that were critiqued.

2.2 Accessibility

The workshop is primarily an engaging discussion, rather than being highly dependent on resources. Much of the course, therefore, is suitable for many as long as the venue is accessible. If attendees have disabilities that limit communication, then appropriate table-specific adaptations can be made to facilitate communication e.g. through the workshop materials on the table. The example reviews are produced in high contrast, and a large font version can be produced if required according to advance attendee information provided.

3 Instructor Background

The course is delivered by Dr Max L. Wilson, as Associate Professor at the University of Nottingham. Max, who sits on the CHI Steering Committee, has been a reviewer for CHI for 15 years, and has reviewed for many other conferences including CSCW, UIST, SIGIR, CHIIR (and its former IliX), ISWC, WWW, UbiComp and MobileHCI. Max has also reviewed for journals including: JASIST, JWS, IJHCI, IP&M, TOIS, TOCHI.

Max has served as a senior reviewer (AC) for CHI and CSCW since 2014, as a Subcommittee Chair (SC) for the Understanding People subcommittee for 3 years, and as Papers Chair for CHI2023 and CHI2024. Max has been an Associate Editor for IJHCS and IP&M, served as the Deputy Editor for IJHCS until 2024, and now acts as Associate Editor-in-Chief for IJHCS starting 2025. Max has also acted as Papers Chair for IliX2014, posters chair for IliX2012, Courses Chair for CHI2016 and CHI2017, Panels Chair for CHI2018, and on the Best Paper Committee for CHIIR2018.

Max has delivered this particular course on eight prior occasions, at national PhD student events, and at specific universities in the United Kingdom.

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⁵SIGCHI Youtube Playlist for the Best Practice in Peer Review Videos.

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